

STREETS OF YOTSUYA

Narrative Design Document – Opening Sequence

Chapter 0: Pre-Title Sequence / Tutorial

1. Scene Overview

Setting

A late-night onsen in Tokyo. Private, humid, almost silent: a space of temporary suspension from the city outside.

Time

Pre-dawn. The city has not woken up yet.

Narrative Function

The opening sequence introduces the protagonist through memory before introducing the world through threat. The transition from flashback to present establishes tone, character and the stakes of the experience before the player is asked to make a single decision.

Gameplay Function

Tutorial. The player's first interaction determines their approach profile for a significant portion of the game. Crucially, the branching point is not a menu choice, it is a perceptual moment. How and when the player notices the threat defines which option becomes available to them.

2. Narrative Context

The Protagonist

Male, mid-twenties. Passionate about cars and underground drift racing: a world he knows intimately. Not a criminal, not a fighter. A troublemaker by temperament rather than profession: someone who moves fast, reads people quickly, and occasionally fails to consider consequences.

He does not own a gun. He is not trained. What he has is instinct, improvisation, and an intimate knowledge of machines.

The Flashback

As the protagonist sits in the onsen, steam in the air, a bottle of Asahi in hand, memory surfaces. A bar in his neighborhood. His father, a man with a drinking problem and an easy laugh,

standing at the counter in front of a wall of smoke. The owner, known only as Bronco: a voice and a glowing cigarette tip, barely visible. The ritual of the large beer and the mango ice pop. The Supra waiting outside.

The flashback is not nostalgic. It carries the specific texture of something important that no longer exists. The protagonist is alone in a way that the memory makes legible.

The transition out of the flashback is sensory: the steam of the onsen bleeds into the smoke of the bar. The same air, a different world.

The Threat

The onsen attendant has gone silent. The small sounds that constituted the background: movement, a distant television, the rhythm of a working space, have stopped.

Someone has come in through a secondary entrance. The attendant has been dealt with: removed, neutralized or fled. The protagonist does not know this yet.

The intruder is a professional. He moves without sound. He is not here by accident.

3. The Object

The protagonist's only available improvised weapon is the bottle of Asahi he was drinking from when the sequence began. It is not a weapon he chose – it is simply what is in his hand.

This detail connects the flashback directly to the present moment. The object associated with his father, with Bronco, with a particular kind of lost warmth, becomes the only thing standing between him and a professional killer. The player does not need to understand this consciously for it to register.

4. Branching Structure

The three gameplay options do not appear as a menu. They emerge from a perceptual sequence: the earlier the player notices the threat, the more options remain available. The branching point is attention, not reaction.

	EARLY — Stealth	MID — Chaotic	LATE — Diplomatic
Trigger	Player notices the silence before the intruder reaches proximity. A door left ajar. The absence of sound that should be there.	Player notices movement or shadow at close range. The intruder is already near. Seconds available.	Player does not notice in time. The intruder is present with weapon drawn before the protagonist reacts.
Action	Hide. Move through the onsen using the environment. Reach the exit without direct confrontation.	Use the bottle. Break it, attack, create chaos. Survive the immediate encounter through force and noise.	Put the bottle down. Raise hands. Attempt to talk.
Immediate Outcome	Exits without being identified. The intruder finds an empty room.	Neutralizes the immediate threat. Loud. The intruder's associates outside are alerted. The chase begins in worse conditions.	Survives the encounter. The intruder, surprised by compliance, does not fire immediately. Protagonist is seen, identified, remembered.
Long-term Cost	The threat is unresolved. The intruder returns, now more cautious. The protagonist has bought time, not safety.	The chase sequence starts compromised. Possible collateral. The intruder, if not fully neutralized, can still report back.	The protagonist is now a known target. The organization sends more and knows exactly who they're looking for. Compliance has made him visible.
Gameplay Impact	Opens stealth-oriented progression paths. Certain contacts trust the protagonist more. Information becomes a primary resource.	Opens confrontation-oriented paths. Reputation in racing and underground circuits increases. Certain doors close, others open.	Severely constrains early options. The protagonist moves through the first act under closer surveillance. Recovery is possible but costly.

Note: The Diplomatic option is not intended as a death state. It is the most costly path: not because talking is wrong, but because compliance in this context signals something specific to the people watching. The game does not punish communication. It punishes the particular kind of conflict avoidance that comes from fear rather than strategy.

5. The Escape

Regardless of option chosen, the sequence ends with the protagonist in his car, a battered Toyota AE86, leaving the onsen at speed. Two vehicles follow, carrying the intruder's associates.

The tutorial driving sequence plays out here. A near-miss or collision with a parked vehicle depending on player performance. The city is empty. The engine fills the streets. The sun is rising ahead of him.

Title Card Sequence

The camera pulls back from the protagonist's POV, revealing the interior of the car, then arcing outward to show the vehicle moving through the waking city from above.

Title on screen: STREETS OF YOTSUYA.

The daylight, in this context, is not reassuring. It is overexposed and disorienting, the light of someone who has not slept and is now moving through a world that operates on rhythms he no longer shares.

6. Tone and Direction

Audio

The sequence is built on absence before presence. The silence of the onsen, the missing sounds, is the first signal. Music enters only with the car: something from the period, chosen for its relationship to momentum rather than genre: Personal Jesus - Depeche Mode.

Visual

Steam, shadow, reflections in water. The intruder is never fully visible until the confrontation point. The player sees what the protagonist sees, and the protagonist sees what he pays attention to.

Design Intention

The opening sequence is intended to establish that this is a world where attention is a survival skill. The player who notices what is wrong before being told to notice it will move through the game differently from the player who waits for a prompt. Both paths are valid. Neither is without cost.